Ship Attacks Near the Strait of Hormuz Reach a Weekly High

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The **Strait** of Hormuz is a narrow waterway in the Middle East. Many **tankers** carry oil through it to the rest of the world. Since the war between the US and Israel and Iran began, ships there have faced attacks.

Twelve ships were reported attacked between October 5 and October 11. That is the highest weekly number reported to the UK Maritime Trade Operations agency since the war started. The week before, 10 ships reported attacks. Six ships were struck on one day, last Sunday. Four more attacks were reported early this week. These numbers are **approximate**, because some reports use the day of the attack and others the day it was reported.

Experts say Iran has been attacking ships to try to gain more control over the waterway. Meanwhile, the US military has been helping more **tankers** travel safely through the southern part of the **strait**. US Navy data shows the number of ships it helped in the first 10 days of October was 85% higher than in the same period in August.

The US military's Central Command said **commercial** ships are still moving through the **strait** with protection from US forces and partners. When one container ship sank this week, all 21 crew members were safely **evacuated**.

The attacks have slowed oil shipments. About 12.6 million **barrels** a day passed through the **strait** on October 13, according to the data firm Kpler. That is down from 15 million at the end of September. Before the war, the number was about 17 million.

Iran says ships using a route near Oman's coast are "unauthorised." One security expert said the aim of the attacks is to stop ships and to discourage others from coming.

Word Treasure

strait -- A narrow stretch of water that connects two larger bodies of water.
tankers -- Large ships built to carry liquids such as oil.
approximate -- Close to the real number, but not exact.
commercial -- Having to do with business and trade rather than the military.
evacuated -- Moved safely away from a dangerous place.
barrels -- A standard unit used to measure amounts of oil.

Background you need

The Strait of Hormuz connects the Persian Gulf to the open ocean, and Iran lies along its northern shore.

Many countries in the Gulf region export oil, and much of it must travel by tanker through this narrow passage.

When ships cannot pass safely, less oil reaches world markets, which can push fuel prices up in other countries.

Navies sometimes escort commercial ships through dangerous waters to help protect them from attack.

Break it down

LEAD: Ship attacks near the Strait of Hormuz reached their highest weekly number since the war began

KEY EVENT: Twelve ships reported attacked between October 5 and October 11

+- WHERE: The Strait of Hormuz, a narrow Middle East waterway for oil tankers

+- WHO: Iran, according to experts; US forces protecting ships

EVIDENCE: UK Maritime Trade Operations reports; US Navy data showing 85% more ships helped

EFFECT: Oil flows fell to about 12.6 million barrels a day on October 13, down from 15 million and a pre-war 17 million

OPEN QUESTION: Will the attacks keep ships away from the strait?

Why it matters

Much of the world's oil travels through this waterway, so attacks there can affect fuel supplies and prices far away.

Test what you remember

1. How many ships were reported attacked between October 5 and October 11?

- (A) Twenty-one
- (B) Twelve
- (C) Ten
- (D) Six

2. Which agency received the reports of attacks?

- (A) Kpler
- (B) UK Maritime Trade Operations
- (C) NASA
- (D) The United Nations

3. Why are the attack numbers described as approximate?

- (A) Some reports use the attack date and others the report date
- (B) The agency closed for a week
- (C) Some ships were never found
- (D) Iran refused to share data

4. How many barrels a day passed through the strait on October 13?

- (A) About 12.6 million
- (B) About 15 million
- (C) About 17 million
- (D) About 6 million

5. What happened to the crew of the container ship that sank this week?

- (A) They were all safely evacuated
- (B) They stayed on board
- (C) They swam to Oman
- (D) They were never found

6. By how much did US Navy help to ships rise in early October compared with August?

- (A) 85%
- (B) 10%
- (C) 50%
- (D) 100%

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Experts: Say Iran is attacking ships to gain more control over the waterway.
2. US Central Command: Says commercial ships are still moving through the strait with protection from US forces and partners.
3. Iran: Says ships using a route near Oman's coast are unauthorised.
4. A security expert: Says the aim of the attacks is to stop ships and discourage others from coming.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):